



Impossible to Miss, Beside the Point

Live Channel-Swap Leaderboards at a Silent Disco Don't Track What the Crowd Preferred

Ingeborg Nwachukwu · Torun Ezeigwe — School of Continuous Improvement

The problem

A 2026 School of Continuous Improvement finding tied a little free library's posted take-vs-leave ratio to neighbours' own ratings only once the placard could actually be read. Would a leaderboard nobody could miss finally let a posted number track what a crowd preferred?

Objectives

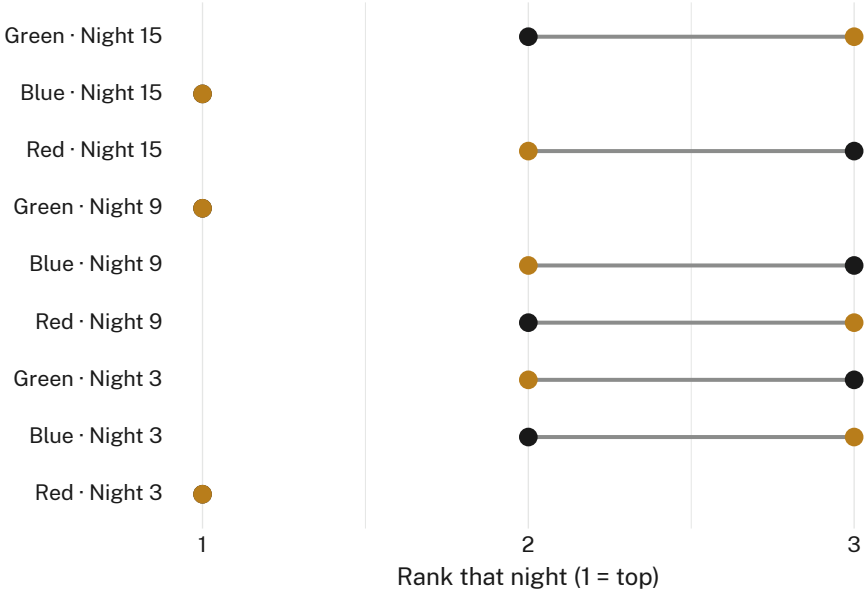
- Test whether a silent disco's live channel-swap-count rank predicts each channel's post-set enjoyment rank.
- Re-run the library study's "legibility, not signal" account somewhere the sign cannot be missed.
- Identify what the posted swap count tracks, if not preference.

Approach

- n = 248 wristbanded attendees · 19 weekly nights · 3 channels per night · Feb–Jun 2026
- Live swap counts read off a centre-truss leaderboard, refreshed every 30 seconds; enjoyment self-rated 1–5 at each channel exit
- Swap-count rank vs enjoyment rank compared per channel-night (Spearman); exit-corridor proximity and launch order logged as covariates, thresholds pre-registered

What we found

Live swap-count rank shows no meaningful association with post-set enjoyment rank across 57 channel-nights ($\rho = 0.11$, ns). The top-ranked channel by swap count matches the top-rated channel by enjoyment in exactly 33% of nights — the rate three unordered channels would match by chance alone.



Live swap-count rank and post-set enjoyment rank agree in 3 of 9 sampled channel-nights (Red/Night 3, Green/Night 9, Blue/Night 15) — exactly the rate three unordered channels would match by chance; the other six show at least a one-rank swap or a full reversal.

Interpretation & where next

The 2026 library study attributed its correlation entirely to placard legibility, predicting an unmissable leaderboard would restore the tracking. It does not: the number is as visible as a number gets, and it still fails to track enjoyment. Swap counts instead index the room's exit corridor ($\rho = 0.68$) and, more weakly, which channel launched first each night ($\rho = 0.44$) — artefacts of layout and running order, not taste.

A visible number, it turns out, is not automatically a valid one: legibility removed one confound and left the layout confound standing in its place.

Next: rotate channel position and launch order nightly to test whether either alone accounts for the correlation the leaderboard actually shows.

Further reading

1. Campbell, D. T. (1979). Assessing the impact of planned social change. *Evaluation and Program Planning*, 2(1), 67–90. doi:10.1016/0149-7189(79)90048-X
2. Manheim, D., & Garraabrant, S. (2018). Categorizing variants of Goodhart's law. arXiv:1803.04585
3. Nwachukwu, I., & Osayande, M. (2026). Posted High, Valued the Same: A Street-Corner Little Free Library's Take-vs-Leave Ratio Against Neighbours' Own Rating of the Box. *School of Continuous Improvement*. doi:10.5555/slop.5l833a
4. Podsakoff, P. M., MacKenzie, S. B., Lee, J.-Y., & Podsakoff, N. P. (2003). Common method biases in behavioral research: A critical review of the literature and recommended remedies. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 88(5), 879–903. doi:10.1037/0021-9010.88.5.879
5. Rudnicki, K., Murrath, T., & Poels, K. (2026). The relation between DJs' behavior and their audience's positive affect and perception of the show: A field study in electronic dance music clubs. *Empirical Studies of the Arts*, 44(1), 82–100. doi:10.1177/02762374251340660
6. Sun, Y., Greaves, D. A., Orgs, G., de C. Hamilton, A. F., Day, S., & Ward, J. A. (2023). Using wearable sensors to measure interpersonal synchrony in actors and audience members during a live theatre performance. *Proc. ACM Interact. Mob. Wearable Ubiquitous Technol.*, 7(1), Article 27. doi:10.1145/3580781

Wristband and survey data de-identified at collection; no audio or video retained. We thank the venue's volunteer stewards for six months of leaderboard tinkering.

Contact: ingeborg.nwachukwu@slop.university · Office of Research Outputs

@slop.university · #slopU

